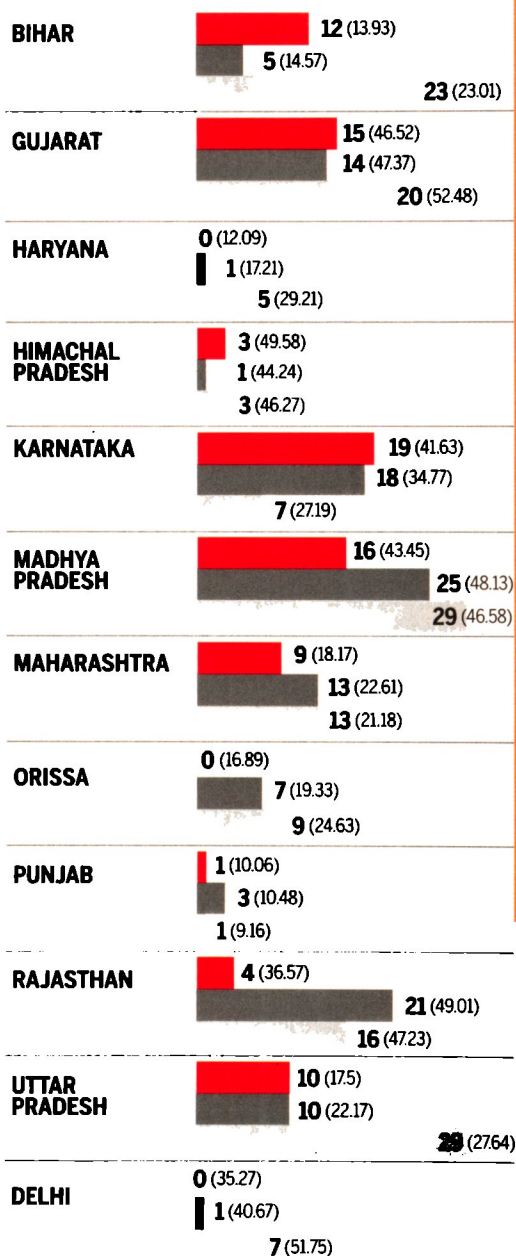


Coverstory **BJP**

1999-2009: A DECADE OF LOSING OUT IN THE LOK SABHA

Its inability to hold on to traditional strongholds cost the BJP dearly

■ 2009
■ 2004
■ 1999



Figures in bold denote seats; in brackets denote vote percentage. All data from Election Commission

most disciplined leaders of the party. His furious fusillade in the form of a letter he circulated at a party meeting questioned the discriminatory punish-and-reward system in the party. Singh demanded some serious soul-searching in the party over the electoral defeat. He was quickly joined by many others, including former finance minister and senior leader Yashwant Sinha. It was clear that a fight was brewing between what is called the Byte Generation and the Substantive Generation, the Old Guard versus the New Pretenders. Meanwhile, cadres watched helplessly from the sidelines as television studios and newspaper columns became convenient platforms for party leaders and functionaries to defend failure. The leadership finally decided to fight back—clumsily as it turned out—by issuing a gag order on party leaders, exposing the communication gap and mistrust in its own ranks.

It is a pivotal moment in the 28-year-old history of the party. When the BJP lost the general elections in 2004, no one in the party held Atal Behari Vajpayee responsible for it. The election was fought



in his name but the slogans, strategy and timing were decided by his anointed successor, L.K. Advani. But there is one crucial difference between 2004 and 2009. Five years back, no one held the party's ideology responsible for the defeat. Back then, there were also leaders who accepted responsibility for the defeat and offered to resign, like Pramod Mahajan.

Turn the page to 2009. The party bagged just 116 seats. However, this time none of the top leaders accepted moral responsibility and offered to resign. Advani made a token offer to resign but withdrew within 24 hours under pressure from those who took the party to disaster and were on

Instead of rewarding the winners and others who worked hard for victory, Advani chose to reward those whom the party cadres saw as the architects of doom.

